

starved to death here. She tosses three *Goodberries* on the floor, before using her web to swing across to the stern.

Still concentrating on *Call Lightning*, Salazar summons another bolt from the skies. It strikes two of the wraiths, and completely vaporises the spirit of Ayo. With all of its undead family destroyed, the last girallon zombie scampers off into the jungle, having lost its home.

Astride Khan, Wang Lei moves to see the wraiths hiding in the dark. He fires another two *Eldritch Blasts* from his eyes, blasting one of the wraiths and drawing its attention. Both of the wraiths whip their head around and dive straight past Wukong's clone and Vilde towards Wang Lei. Both of them land an attack of opportunity on the vengeful spirits.

The wraiths reach Wang Lei just in time for Hazel to leap in front of the paladin, allowing the last *Spirit Guardians* to smite and disintegrate the spirits of Sylvio and Bravewing.

With the combat over, Vilde uses her web to pull the rest of the Party up. As they gather around Thaisha to check on the half-orc, she asks about Ayo.

"We should bury her," Thaisha says. "We may have had our tensions, but she was an invaluable part of our team. We should show her the proper respect."

"It's okay," Salazar lies. "I've buried her already."

"Oh really?" Thaisha asked, confused. "When would you have the time during the fight to do that?"

"Well, that was a lie," Vilde says, her eyes narrow accusingly at the wizard. "I saw what happened to her. The wraiths, they drained the life out of her. She's gone. There was no body. Also," The rogue turns to Hazel. "The Hag's Bane's missing. I don't see it here."

As the Party continues to discuss their next steps, they suddenly realize that Raphael is missing. Unbeknownst to the rest, the sorcerer has *Misty Step* to the end section of the ship.

COLOR OUT OF SPACE

Entering the end of the ship, you see that this room is occupied. Standing in the middle of the room is a thin, unnaturally tall humanoid with pale white skin and a featureless face. He is wearing nothing, and carrying what looks like a huge paintbrush. He has his back against all of you, and is not moving at all.

His attention seems to be focused on something in the desk: a small, wooden locked box. Raphael, you recognize the crest on this box - it is your house's crest.

Pulling out his signet ring, Raphael presents it to the entity. Waving it around, the creature ignores the sorcerer. Remembering the phrases carved around the ship, Raphael realizes that the aberration in front of him must be his father.

Webbing across, Vilde helps everyone make their way into the end section of the ship. As the Party arrives, they watch as Raphael steps out of reach of the aberration, his hand closing around the box.

As you go for the box, the creature inhales a suffocating vortex, stripping the vibrant hues from your flesh, armor, and soul. The world bleeds out into a dull grey as the stolen brilliance implodes into a blinding, sickly yellow light above. Reality tears open beneath your feet as all of you plunge through the fracture, landing violently upon cold stone slab ruins within a murky, submerged shrine echoing with crimson power. Surrounding you, pulsing blood-red orbs and sinister tentacles writhe against the abyssal darkness.

Raphael, this sight is not unfamiliar to you. You've seen this place before, in your dreams. All of you gain Resistance to Psychic damage just as a look of realization passes over the sorcerer. You are all trapped in Raphael's mind.

THE DANGEROUS MIND OF RAPHAEL ANTARRA

Trapped in Raphael's mind, the Party suffers the following effects:

- *Resistance to Psychic Damage.* Raphael empowers the Party with the same mental fortitude he has.
- *Lair Actions.* On initiative count 20, Raphael rolls a d20 dice. He can record the dice result and replace any d20 test using his Reaction.
- *Environmental Damage.* Any area-of-effect damage cast by the Party dealt from a spell deals quarter damage to Raphael.
- *Erased of Name.* If Raphael dies, all those who are trapped in his mind dies.
- *Chains of Fate.* Any damage that Raphael takes, the Party takes half.

In addition, as they combat the *Color Out Of Space*, colors are stripped magically from the Party. On a failed DC 20 Constitution saving throw, a creature has their color stolen. A creature that has a color stolen suffers the corresponding effects:

- *Red.* The creature cannot regain hit points.
- *Blue.* The creature cannot cast spells of 1st level or higher.
- *Yellow.* The creature cannot take Reactions.

The horrific drain leaves its mark. As the blinding yellow glare fades, the physical toll of the vortex becomes terrifyingly clear. Most of the Party has been hollowed out: Mason and Raphael look down at their

hands to find the rich, deep blues of their attire, armor and person completely eradicated. Across from them, Wang Lei and Thaisha suffer the opposite tragedy: the warm yellow tints of their golden filigree and holy symbols have been violently ripped away.

Wukong stands alone, bathed in absolute, sickening monochrome red. The creature's siphon had devoured every trace of yellow and blue from his form, leaving his fur, armor, and skin looking as though they were painted in fresh, wet crimson. Beside him, Hazel has had her red and yellow hues stripped clean to the soul, rendering the cleric unnervingly blue.

Vilde and Salazar stand untarnished. By sheer force of will, their flesh, armor, and gear retain their full, brilliant spectrum, casting them as surreal beacons of normalcy amidst the nightmare.

As all of you get ready for combat, you see that the Color is not the only thing here. While most of the Color is absorbed into the aberration, all of you see three colorful ink blots swirl around you. They solidify, each becoming a splitting image of a handsome man with a scruff and a long overcoat. Two of them are completely yellow, while the last one is completely blue.

"My dear boy," all three of them say, their words echoing in this cavernous place. "I had hoped you never make it here."

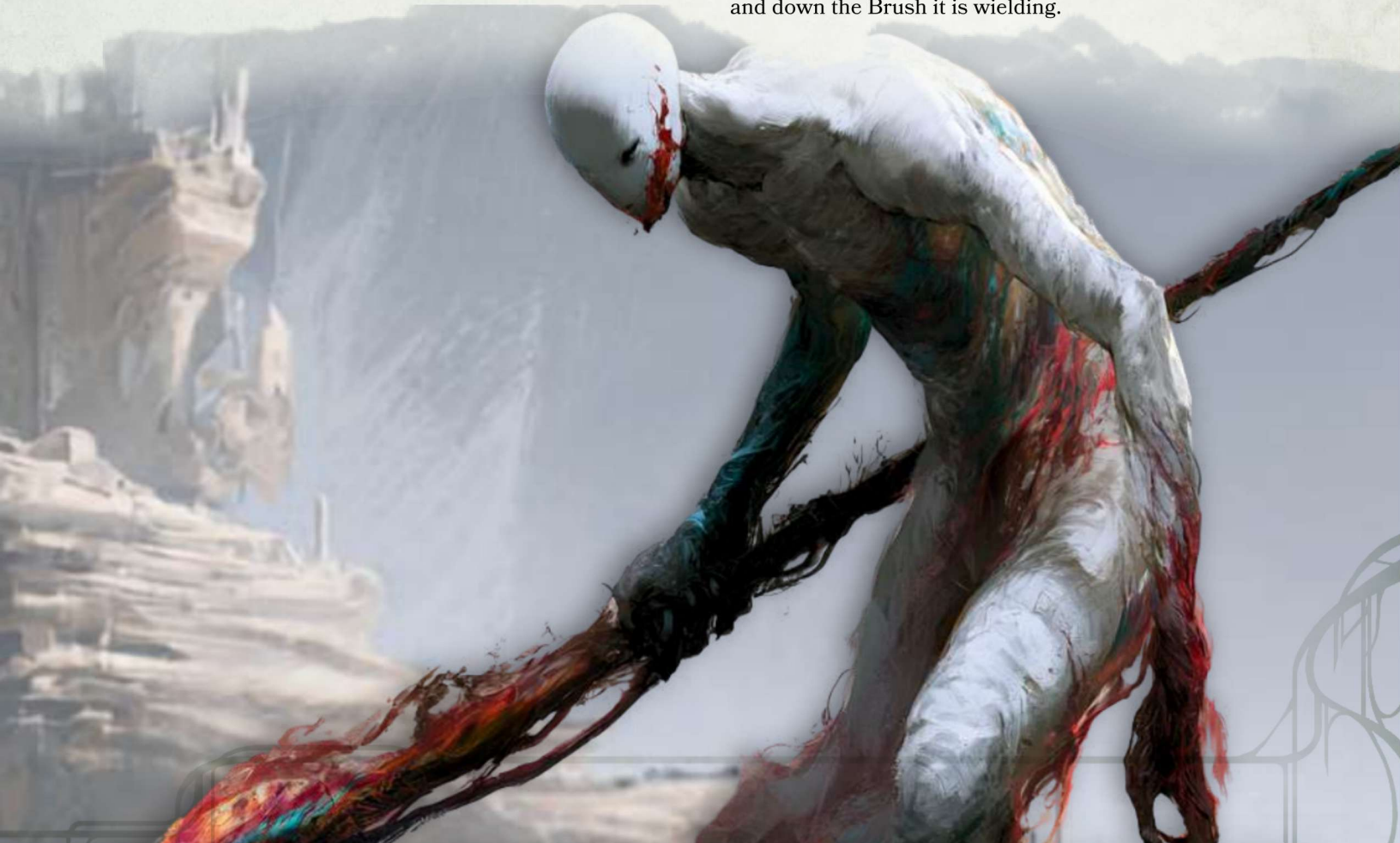
Raphael recognizes the ink men, who looks like his father the Lord Antarra. "Father? What's happening? Why are you here?"

"The family... is wrong," the three ink men speak in unison, their movements echoing one another. "Forget the Key and the Gate. You must convince the rest of our family to stop and abandon their mission. They must not open the Gate!"

Whilst the ink men are engaging in conversation, Vilde and Wang Lei race into action. The rogue leaps down from the rocky outcrop, rushing forward and hiding behind a large stone column. Wang Lei's pauldron glows green as the paladin flits forward like the vanquished wraiths. As he raises his holy symbol to cast *Shield of Faith* on himself, the blue Lord Antarra snaps his fingers and fires a *Counterspell*.

"Okay, fine," Wang Lei says. He charges his mace with thunderous energy as he attacks the yellow ink man with *Booming Blade*. The undead girallon zombie follows his master's lead, leaping up and tearing into the ink man. As the zombie monkey eviscerates the yellow Lord Antarra, Wang Lei sees streaks of lightning within the ink blot, which explodes outwards in a crackling wave. As the lightning strikes the paladin, yellow hues return to the paladin.

The monstrous, pale white creature known as the Color Out Of Space lumbers forward towards the Party. On its face, drawn unceremoniously and plastered ear-to-ear is an unnerving grin in bright red. Iridiscent colors flow up and down the Brush it is wielding.



Recognizing that the Party is in Raphael's head and would likely all die if he dies, Hazel casts *Bless* on Raphael, Vilde and herself. The cleric dashes to the right side of the battlefield, hoping to find cover behind another stone column. Thaisha follows suit, casting *Cure Wounds* on Raphael before darting to the left and spreading out.

Wukong enlarges his *Jingubang* and follows Thaisha, waiting to see what happens next.

Despite having one of his copies destroyed, the Lord Antarra remains unperturbed. Both the blue and the yellow ink men dashes towards Raphael, closing distance. The yellow ink Lord Antarra grabs Raphael, cradling his face and breaking down into tears. "My boy," he says. "I've been here for... who knows how long. I Opened the Gate and communed with the entity beyond. I - it has been grooming us, like cattle. It wants to be born. It wants to take over your mind, the only one strong enough to withstand Its presence."

Mason follows his knight's lead, attacking the yellow ink man currently holding Raphael. His silvered shortsword cleaves through the ink like butter, which reforms almost instantaneously. The yellow Lord Antarra did not seem to have felt the strike; his desperate eyes scan Raphael's, looking to convince the sorcerer.

A million thoughts race through Raphael's mind. He wonders if the yellow ink blot is even his real father. He considers the possibility that the mission he has been given from his family is all a lie. He questions if he can even trust the man in yellow in front of him right now. As the thoughts race through his mind, the sorcerer's telekinetic powers awaken instinctively.

Like a lance, Raphael pierces into the mind of the yellow Lord Antarra in front of him. He extracts a vision, an image that is broadcasted to the Party with him.

You see an old man on a posh bed back in your manor in Antaril. Raphael, you recognise this as your grandfather Cassian. His eyes are completely white; he has no pupils. Beside this man, crying, is the Lady Isolde, your grandmother. Grasping your grandfather's hand, by his bedside, is your father, the soon-to-be Lord Antarra.

"Castellan, please," your grandfather says. "I saw what lies beyond the Gate. It... is not a god. It is not a demon. It is something older. Something that has always been, and always will be. It spoke to me, not in words but in images. It showed me what it wants. It showed me our purpose. Find the Key. Open the Gate. We are meant to. We have always been meant to. We were chosen."

Raphael realizes that this is a genuine memory. He concludes that the ink blots are whatever remains of his father's consciousness, and that the Color Out Of Space is some kind of servant of the entity.

"Okay, I guess we're fighting," Vilde says. The rogue joins Wang Lei and his undead minion monkey in combat against the Color Out Of Space. She hurls her dagger, striking the chromatic aberration deep in its heart. As she does so, she draws its attention long enough for the paladin to charge his mace up with thunder and divine power. Wang Lei leaps forward, kicking off a tentacle that erupts from the ground courtesy of Raphael and brings the mace down on the back of the monster's head with the force of a meteor strike. Thunder and divine heat radiate out in a fiery explosion as the monster stumbles forward.

The Color Out Of Space turns and slashes across the paladin's chest with its Void Brush. He is knocked back as the blue tint of his cape is sucked out. The blue ink coalesces into a new copy of the Lord Antarra. The undead monkey snarls, leaping off the same tentacle summoned by Raphael to land on and attack the Color viciously.

Intuiting that a powerful area-of-effect spell may be detrimental to Raphael, Salazar elects to cast *Fire Bolt*. The Color moves with supernatural celerity, waving its paint brush in a huge stroke. It splatters red paint into the air, which absorbs the mote of fire.

The huge aberration lumbers forward, detonating the thunderous forcefield Wang Lei placed around it. All of the colors around it swirl in a dizzying dance as it releases a powerful chromatic blast. The iridescent wave washes over Thaisha, Wukong and Mason, searing them in burning color. The druid falls unconscious as the paladin struggles not to lose control of his lycanthropy. The released ink twirls in the air, forming small eddy currents before fusing back with Raphael and Wukong. The red ink blends into a new, red copy of the Lord Antarra.

The cleric, taking cover behind a massive stone column and avoiding the blast, summons her duplicate. As the duplicate leaps forward, she casts *Healing Word* on Wukong. The paladin wakes up Thaisha, bringing her back into the fight.

"Its name is Yog-So'Thoth," the yellow Lord Castellan Antarra explains. "Please, my dear boy, please. You have to stop them. They will never understand." Raphael looks out at the destruction all around him as Wang Lei, Mason, Vilde and the undead monkey continue to fight the towering monster. He watches as it beats back all of them, and wheels around on Salazar and Hazel. The yellow ink man continues, "Forgive me my son. I did not know our family's mission was like this."



"It may have given us Its power, but it cannot be taken away," The Lord Antarra begs. "We need not follow Its bidding." The sorcerer remains quiet, a trait he did not realize he had picked up from Hinari. He calculates the possibilities and where each course of action will lead him.

Meanwhile, the monster strikes the wizard with his Void Brush. As the brush descends, Salazar raises his staff and screams "*Expelliarmus!*" A mystical arcane shield erupts from him as the weapon is knocked out of the Color's hands. The wizard catches the huge paintbrush with both of his hands, stumbling backwards at the weight. As he does so, the intelligent wizard intuits the workings of the magical weapon, learning that the stolen hues are powering the weapon. He also learns how to return the colors to the rest of the Party.

"Uh guys, should I return the colors he stole or just hit him with it?" Salazar shouts as he scurries back from the aberration.

"Just hit him with it!" Wang Lei urges.

The wizard, having never used a great weapon before in his life, swings it clumsily. The Color Out Of Space ducks the swing by merely stepping aside.

"Okay, never mind!" The wizard screams as he scampers away. The undead monkey slams into the monstrosity, slashing and tearing away at its pale white flesh. The Color ignores the girallon zombie, instead chasing the wizard that had stolen its weapon. He seizes the Void Brush, lifting it and the wizard high in the air. With a shake, he breaks the wizard's grip on the

weapon, forcing him to tumble into the ground below. As the wizard falls, the Color Out Of Space raises the Void Brush over its head and brings it down twice, pummeling the wizard with incredible power into unconsciousness. Hazel mutters a quick prayer, casting *Healing Word* to bring the wizard back only for him to be pulverised again by the Void Brush back into unconsciousness.

"I'll help you, father," Raphael lies as easily as he breathes. "I will stop them." The sorcerer raises his hand as energy swirls around his fingers. Unleashing a *Sorcerous Burst*, the blast of energy strikes the back of the shoulder of the aberration and draws its attention.

CHARISMA (DECEPTION) CHECK

On a DC 20 check, Raphael succeeds in fooling his father - or what's left of him.

Having been knocked back by the aberration, Vilde takes a minute to rest on the floor. She wonders aloud what loot might be in this place. As she does so, a +2 *Dagger* spawns into existence in front of her, coalescing like ink in a fluid.

"Woah, cool," she says. "Guys, look what I found!" The rogue hurls the Dagger at the aberration, shattering like glass against its skin. "Okay, never mind!" Vilde draws her own *Dagger of Returning*, throwing it again at the Color Out Of Space.

Wang Lei closes distance, healing Salazar and bringing him back to life. The paladin and his monkey charge at

the Color once again, slamming his mace into the monster and wreathing him in booming energy. The snarling monkey sinks its teeth in the Color's slender neck, ripping out entire chunks.

With zero emotion, the Color kicks Salazar back as he slashes his Void Brush in a giant arc, cutting the paladin and his undead monkey, in a storm of force and lightning. Salazar and Wang Lei both crumple to the ground, unconscious again.

"Not again!" Hazel casts *Healing Word* once again, bringing Salazar back up for the third time. Thaisha heals Raphael as well, looking at the sorcerer to see what he would do. The athletic Wukong fishes out a *Potion of Healing*, tossing it across the rocky outcrop with pinpoint accuracy and breaking it on Wang Lei, reviving his fellow paladin.

Raphael's bloodwell vial glows with malevolent purple light as he channels the raw arcana in his veins into a *Sorcerous Burst*. He shares a look with the featureless face of the Color, trying to communicate an understanding of some kind.

WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK

Failing a DC 20 check, Raphael is unsure whether or not the Color Out Of Space understood that Raphael is still willing to Open the Gate.

A roiling ball of thunder detonates from inside the Color Out Of Space, imploding the aberration from inside and showering the Party with brilliant viscera. As the steaming innards covers the Party, they are thrown out of Raphael's mind and back into their bodies aboard the Wreck of the Star Goddess.

Returning back into the captain's quarters, all of you see that the aberration is gone. Raphael, you are now holding the box in front of you.

INTELLIGENCE (INVESTIGATION) CHECK

Succeeding on a DC 20 check, Vilde finds a letter on the desk; it had been held down previously by the box. The dust and grime on this letter is much lesser its surroundings, suggesting that this letter came much later. She pockets it without saying a word.

Raphael opens the box to take a look, but quickly closes it again.

"What the hells was that?" Thaisha asks. "W-we were in your head."

"Uh, yeah," Raphael asks. "I - I'm not really sure what happened."

"Yeah, no," Thaisha demands. "I almost died. Wang Lei almost died. Salazar almost died. We deserve a bit more than that."

"Stop questioning me," the sorcerer seethes. "We've all just been through a lot."

"Yeah, it's alright," Salazar says. "Personally, I'm fine."

Thaisha's rage switches over to the wizard. "Why do you let them treat you this way? Like you don't matter?"

"I'm not," Salazar shoots a look at Raphael, subtly pointing his thumb over to Thaisha as if to say 'get a load of this guy.' He winks deceptively, "I think it's fine, he'll let us know in time."

"Yes, I think tensions are running high, but you do owe us an explanation, Raphael," Vilde says. "We can all rest up, get a good meal, and then talk about it when we're all feeling better. How's that?"

The Party acquiesces, heading out of the wreck. Wang Lei finds Ayo's belongings, looting it and passing the *Hag's Bane* to Hazel and Thaisha. The pair head off to heal the Poisoned Duo as the the rest of the Party eat a quick, quiet lunch before setting up camp with the Commander's Tent and resting.

WHAT'S IN THE BOX?

Waking up earlier than the others, Vilde reads the letter she found: addressed to Raphael's father from Lord Atakan Tokugane, it spoke of how Atakan's daughter had recently found employment with the Court of Owls and suggested that House Antarra and House Tokugane work together by betrothing Raphael to Hinari so as to seize control of the Court of Owls and perhaps use it on Cer'Dorei, the elven nation.

She pours over Raphael's dossier, and learns that Raphael was linked with Hinari during their time together in the Society of the Six. She also learns that Lord Atakan rules over the city of Ryoko, and is the current patriarch of House Tokugane, a human house of clockwork soul sorcerers.

Vilde then cooks up a buffet of deep-fried bananas and acai as the Party rouses from their sleep. The Party gathers for dinner, sitting in a silent circle around the campfire.

"So," Thaisha asks. "What's in the box?"

Raphael produces it, passing its contents around. "I had some time to gather my thoughts," He begins. "I take it you all saw the vision of my grandfather by his bedside. He was the first one that Opened the Gate. He did it during the Sundering War to give my family powers in the war. Then, my father, he came here fifteen years ago to Nagalore in search of the Gate. I guess he Opened it. The ink men we saw, the blots of color that were talking

to me, that must be the remnants of him. Whatever's left of him. And the Color Out Of Space must be a servant or something of the entity that he claims lies beyond the Gate."

"And what is this entity?" Vilde asks. "Where did it come from?"

"As I'm sure you all know, sorcerers like me draw power from our bloodline," Raphael explained. "The entity must be the thing that infused my family's bloodline with Its power. As to where it came from, I have no clue, but it must lie beyond the Gate. The search of It has been my family's motto, mission really, since I was a little boy." Turning to Thaisha, Raphael continues, "This ship is my father's. They crashed here, and when I went for the box we were all sucked into my head. Here's the strange thing: the Color Out Of Space did not hurt me. I was caught in the wave of its Color Blast and it didn't hurt me, just gave me my colors back. I'm not sure why, too."

"And this entity, it has a name?" Wang Lei asked. "Is it still a threat to us?"

Raphael nodded. "Yog-So'Thoth. And for your second question, I'm not sure. Maybe."

Having been quiet inspecting the contents of the box, Hazel, Thaisha and Salazar sees a circlet of gnarled onyx, with purple barbs designed to dig into the head of the wearer. Beneath it, a monstrous-looking tome bound in humanoid skin with an almost palpable aura of dread. There is a grotesque and ghoulish face stretched across its loathsome cover.

"That's the Nekronomicon," Raphael says. "I think he was reading up on it. In any case, he might have left me clues at Nagalore. We should probably find some time to head there."

"And what clues might that be?" Thaisha asks. "Are you trying to find this... Yog-So'Thoth? Open the Gate and bring It here?"

"It's my family's goal to find out the truth," Raphael lies. "I think I need more information than that. For all I know, my father could be lying."

WISDOM (INSIGHT) CHECK

On a nat 20 check, Thaisha sees right through Raphael.

"And are you going to open the Gate or not?" Hazel asks. "Your father said not to do it, back in your mind."

"I will need more information," He says. "I can't say for sure -"

"I'm not going to Nagalore," Thaisha shoots a look at Wang Lei and Hazel. "I am not helping you Open the

Gate so that an otherworldly entity can break into our world. Are you? Or you? Or any of you?" She points at Wang Lei and Hazel, before gesturing to the rest of the Party.

"Well, if we do, we can kill it," Wang Lei responds. A tense silence falls over the group.

"In any case, it is not a pressing matter," Vilde speaks up. "We need to focus on the problem at hand." She produces the letter from Lord Atakan Tokugane, passing it around to the others.

Reading the letter, Salazar shares with the Party what he knows about the Court of Owls. He shares an urban myth he has heard about them as an international organisation of assassins who seek to bring order to the world. Vilde shares her conclusions, but remains unsure if Lord Atakan's plot to seize control of the organisation was successful.

Discussion over what the Court of Owls is continues in earnest. Nobody sees Raphael unfurl a small note that had been left in the box which he had kept to himself. The note is simple; written in his father's handwriting are the words: "Raphael. September 29, 790 AY. Scorching Sands. Black dragon's blood will Open the Way."

Vilde. Your Sending stone pings.

"YOUR LETTERS ARE HERE!" Firebeard's voice rings out from the stone. "ALSO, YOU HAVE VISITORS. THE LADY ARIANWEN HAS ARRIVED. SHE IS ASKING TO SEE VILDE."

"Oh, no," the rogue says, fishing the stone out of her pocket. Instinctively, she says into the stone. "Did they bring my scimitars, and also did my mum look angry?"

The stone does not respond.

"Wait, shit," Vilde curses. "He's deaf!"